wanted Nair to nose around a bit before returning to Delhi. Nair, a Malayalee, was pretending to be a Hindi-speaking man to eavesdrop on policemen. Later Nair told me he had to struggle not be biased against the Kerala police, as the conversations at the police station were about 'fixing' rather than finding the truth.

The Vanchiyoor Police took me to Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Anil Kumar.

'Do you plead guilty?' were his first words.

'What's the charge?' I asked.

A court clerk brought a plain white paper and asked me to sign. I asked what it was for, and he said some formalities. I did not want to sign on a blank paper, but I had to. So I signed on the top end of the paper so that they wouldn't write something above it and hold me responsible for having endorsed it. I looked around the courtroom. There was a crowd outside, but I couldn't find any friend or acquaintance. Another round of scanning and I saw a familiar face—that of Raj Chengappa, a journalist who had been in touch with me while doing stories on ISRO. I called out to him and he said something sympathetic. The Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate remanded me in police custody for eleven days. Now I was officially an accused in the ISRO spy case.

When I came out of the courtroom there was a huge, swelling crowd. Press photographers jostled with each other to get a good shot of mine. A policeman offered a towel and told me I could use is to cover my face. I refused. Among the crowd were two or three familiar faces, including that of Gopinath, a clerk in the medical section of ISRO. Later, I was told that many friends and colleagues had come there.

I was still in shock, then a trance. At one instance it appeared to me that I was watching a movie—with me as the central character. Here I was watching at myself from a distance, being arrested and taken to prison for having sold India's rocket science secrets to an enemy country. In the brief and intermittent moments of my return from the trance, such questions bolted through my mind: Why did this happen? Who is behind this